

Your Friendly Neighbourhood

Assessment 1 Project Proposal - Draft 0.9

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SDG: Goal 11 - Sustainable Cities and Communities

1. Project overview and SDG rationale

Your Friendly Neighbourhood is a decision-support website for renters unfamiliar with Melbourne, including new immigrants, international students and interstate migrants. Users will compare two or three Greater Melbourne Statistical Areas Level 2 (SA2s) using housing, transport, population growth and green-space indicators.

The interface will explain that an SA2 may represent one suburb, part of a suburb or several localities. The project supports SDG targets 11.1 (housing), 11.2 (transport), 11.3 (urbanisation) and 11.7 (green spaces). Its indicators are local proxies, not official UN measurements.

We selected SDG 11 because Melbourne's growth is pressuring housing, transport and green space. The project helps renters compare these conditions before investigating where to live.

2. Issue, research and news evidence

Greater Melbourne gained approximately 105,000 residents, or 2%, during 2024-25, although growth varied substantially between areas (Australian Bureau of Statistics, 2026).

ABC News reported calls for more hospital and transport infrastructure in Melbourne's rapidly growing north. Other reporting describes outer-suburban residents facing long journeys and limited services. These findings show why renters should not consider housing cost alone.

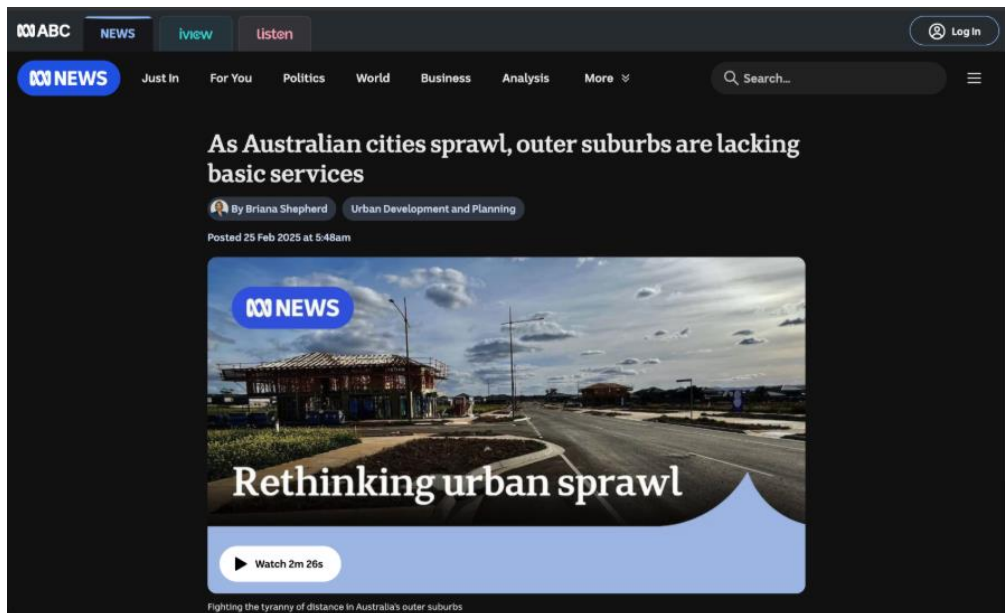


Figure 1: ABC News reporting on infrastructure and service gaps in rapidly growing outer suburbs, illustrating the location trade-offs that renters may encounter.

Our research found that the necessary open data is available but not immediately comparable. ABS data uses SA2 geography, while transport and open-space data require spatial processing. Reference years differ, and the open-space dataset is not maintained. The website must display each indicator's source, year and limitations.

3. Problem statement

A renter unfamiliar with Melbourne needs to compare selected SA2s consistently to balance housing affordability, transport access, population growth and green-space provision, but faces fragmented datasets with different formats, years, measures and boundaries.

The challenge is not missing information; it is turning fragmented information into a clear initial comparison.

4. Target audience and stakeholders

The primary audience is renters unfamiliar with Melbourne, including new immigrants, international students and interstate migrants. They need to identify possible areas, understand differences and decide where to investigate further.

Other stakeholders include universities, migrant and settlement services, Consumer Affairs Victoria, renter-support organisations, Victorian agencies, councils and communities represented by the data.

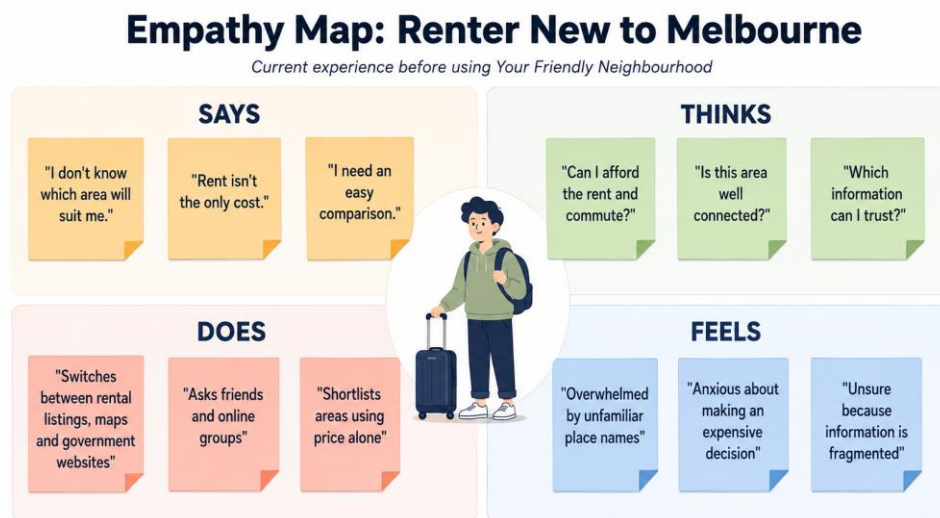


Figure 2: Current-experience empathy map illustrating what a renter says, thinks, does and feels when trying to understand unfamiliar Melbourne areas using fragmented information sources.

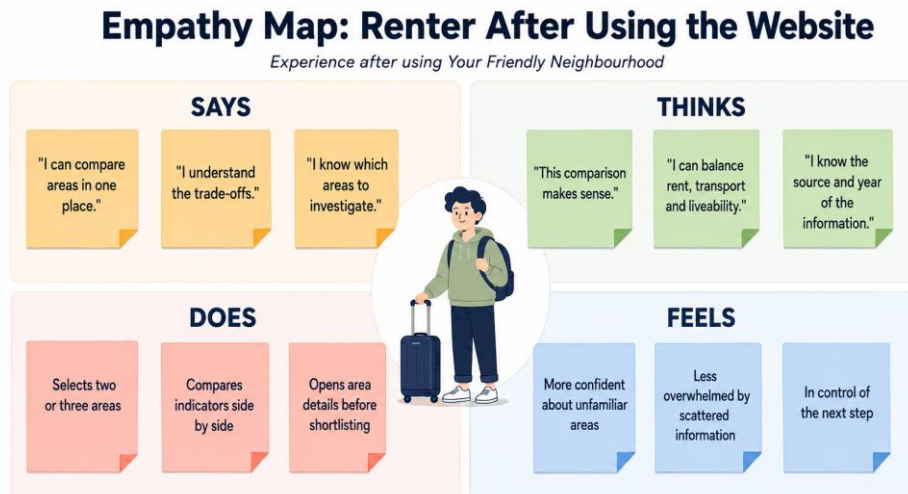


Figure 3: Future-experience empathy map illustrating how a renter may say, think, act and feel after using Your Friendly Neighbourhood to compare unfamiliar Melbourne areas.

5. Proposed solution and value

The website will contain:

- A Home page explaining its purpose and limitations

- A Compare page for selecting two or three SA2s
- An Area Details page showing indicators and trends

It will highlight trade-offs such as lower housing pressure with limited transport access. It will not rank areas, provide financial advice or tell renters where to live. It offers a transparent starting point without manually combining government datasets.

6. Open data and scoring logic

Proposed sources include:

1. ABS Regional Population
2. ABS 2021 Census DataPacks
3. DataVic Public Transport Accessibility Level
4. DataVic Metropolitan Melbourne Open Space
5. ABS SA2 boundaries for spatial preparation

The data will be cleaned, aligned through SA2 codes and stored in a master database. Each indicator will become a percentile relative to eligible Greater Melbourne SA2s:

- **Growth pressure:** five-year growth rate and absolute population increase
- **Housing pressure:** median rent relative to median household income
- **Transport access:** summarised PTAL result
- **Green-space provision:** open space per 1,000 residents and land-area share

The website will show raw values, ratings, source years and limitations. Missing data will not equal zero. Ratings describe relative area conditions and do not determine whether a property is personally affordable.

7. User journey, epics and wireframes

The proposed journey is:

Learn about the product → select SA2s → compare indicators → open Area Details → review sources and limitations

The main epics are selecting an SA2, comparing two or three areas, understanding one area in detail, and understanding the supporting evidence and limitations.

A neighbourhood comparison tool for renters new to Melbourne

Find an area that better fits your everyday needs

Compare rent, transport, population and green-space information without searching through separate government datasets.

Search for a Melbourne area

Try Clayton, Carlton or Footscray

Start comparing

Areas are based on ABS SA2 statistical boundaries and may not exactly match suburb boundaries.

What you can compare



Rent and housing

Compare renter-relevant housing costs and pressure indicators.



Public transport

Understand relative access to public transport services.



Population change

See how quickly an area has recently grown or changed.



Green space

Review relative access to available open and green space.

Figure 4: Home page wireframe showing how renters can search for a Melbourne area and explore the four available comparison categories.

Compare Melbourne areas

Choose two or three SA2 areas and review renter-relevant information using the same measures.

Add an area

Add area

Clayton SA2

Footscray SA2

Add one more area

Comparison overview

Measure	Clayton SA2	Footscray SA2	What it means
Median weekly rent Housing - latest available year	\$480	\$520	Typical advertised or reported rent level for comparison.
Public transport access Relative area score	72 / 100 Stronger access	84 / 100 Stronger access	Relative access compared with eligible Melbourne SA2 areas.
Recent population growth Historical, not forecast	6.4%	3.1%	Indicates recent change that may affect demand for services and housing.
Green space per resident Square metres per person	18 m²	12 m²	A relative indication of available green and open space.

Scores are relative, based on open data and not a guarantee of personal suitability.

Continue exploring

Clayton SA2
Review values, sources, reference years and explanations for this area.

View Clayton details

Footscray SA2
Review values, sources, reference years and explanations for this area.

View Footscray details

Figure 5: Compare page wireframe showing how renters can compare multiple areas.

[← Back to comparison](#)

Clayton SA2

A renter-focused summary of housing, transport, population change and green space.

An SA2 is a statistical area and may not exactly match the suburb boundary.

Area overview



Median weekly rent

\$480 per week

Typical reported rent level for area comparison.

Source: housing data · latest available year



Public transport access

72 / 100

Stronger access

Relative access compared with eligible Melbourne SA2s.

Source: PTAL data · source year shown in product



Recent population growth

6.4% five-year change

Shows recent area change; this is historical, not a forecast.

Source: ABS Regional Population · source years shown



Green space per resident

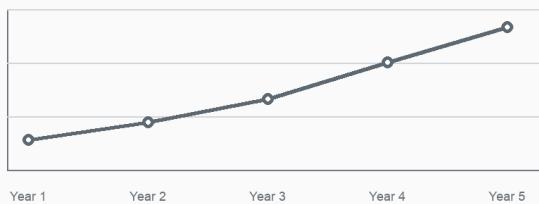
18 m² per person

Relative indication of available green and open space.

Source: DataVic Open Space · source year shown

Population trend

Five-year population change



What this may mean

The area has experienced population growth, which may increase demand for housing, transport and local services.

Interpret with the other indicators.

Before you decide

These results are relative area indicators, not a recommendation or guarantee of personal suitability. Check current listings, travel needs and local services before making a rental decision.

[Back to comparison](#)[Compare with another area](#)

Figure 6: Area Details page wireframe showing renter-relevant indicators, recent population change and supporting explanations for a selected Melbourne area.

8. System architecture

The system will collect open datasets, clean and combine them in a database, apply consistent comparison logic and display the results through the website. The initial product will require no account and retain no personally identifiable information.

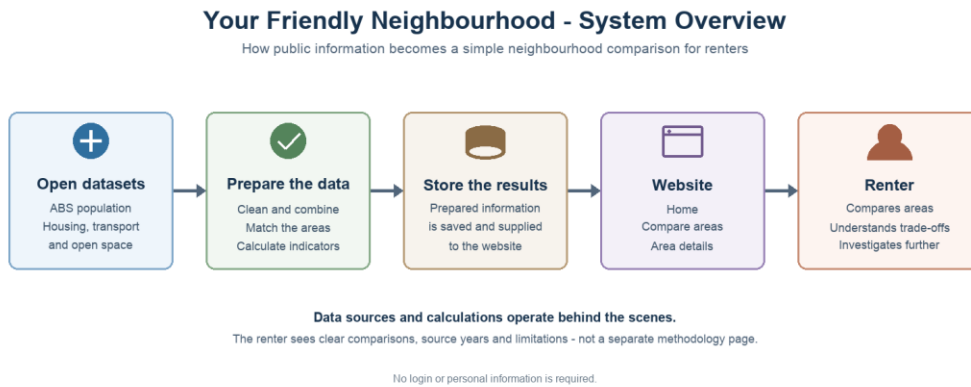


Figure 7: Non-technical system architecture showing how open datasets are prepared and presented through the Your Friendly Neighbourhood website.

9. Ethics and limitations

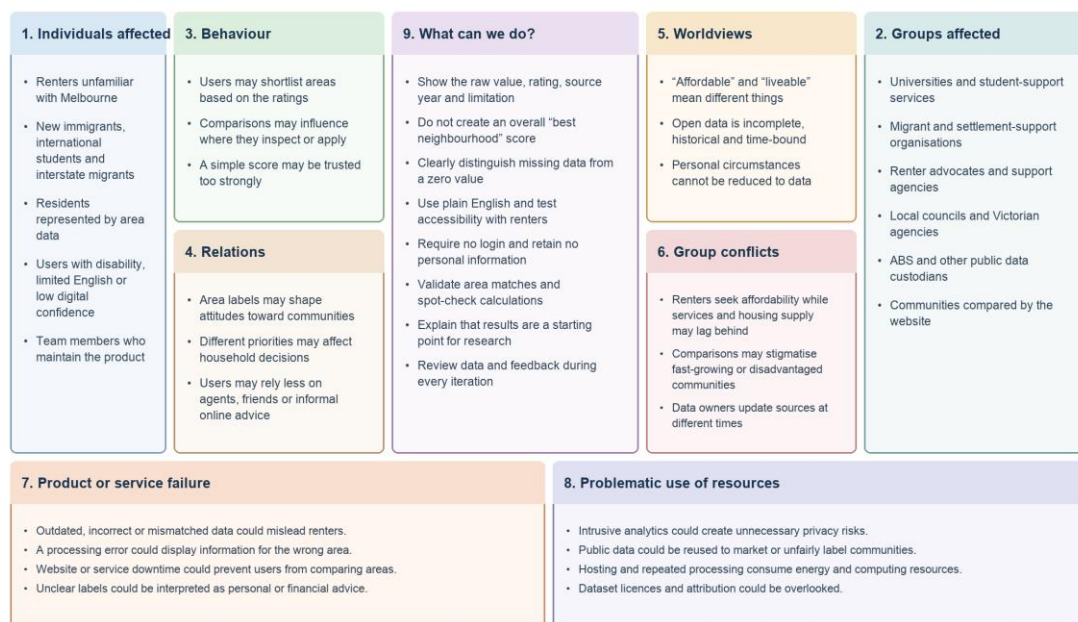
Risks include oversimplified ratings, indicators being mistaken for recommendations, inconsistent reference years, outdated or missing data, extreme percentages in small SA2s, community stigma and confusion between SA2 and suburb boundaries.

Safeguards include transparent calculations, source years, missing-data warnings, no overall "best area" score and advice to conduct further research. No personal information will be collected.

Ethics Canvas

Project: Your Friendly Neighbourhood

Date: September 2026



Structure adapted from Ethics Canvas v1.8, ethicscanvas.org (ADAPT Centre, Trinity College Dublin and Dublin City University), CC BY-SA 3.0.

Figure 8: Ethics Canvas identifying affected stakeholders, potential ethical impacts and proposed safeguards for Your Friendly Neighbourhood.

10. Iteration 1 plan and success

Iteration 1 will deliver a deployed website using ABS population and housing data.

Deliverable	Acceptance condition
Home page	Purpose, audience and limitations are clear
Compare page	User can compare two SA2s
Area Details	Population trend and housing results are displayed
Database	Cleaned data can be retrieved by SA2 code
Deployment	Complete journey works on the hosted website

Success means the journey works without critical errors, results show their evidence, and test users can understand each rating and identify a meaningful trade-off.

11. Potential sponsor

Consumer Affairs Victoria is a possible sponsor because it supports Victorian renters. Study Melbourne, universities, settlement services or renter advocates could contribute user knowledge, testing and promotion.

12. Conclusion and feedback

Your Friendly Neighbourhood will transform fragmented open data into a transparent starting point for renters investigating unfamiliar Melbourne areas.

The team seeks feedback on whether the audience is sufficiently specific, the indicators are meaningful, SA2 geography is appropriate, Iteration 1 is achievable and the proposed sponsor is suitable.

References

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